Tamil Nadu by converting to Christianity, which meant that they were subjected to fewer prohibitions. However, the bulk of the Thiyyas and Ezhavas refused to follow suit and suffered accordingly. One of their number was that *mulachi* or 'breasted woman' from Cherthala, the Ezhava by the name of Nangeli, wife of Chirukandan, who in response to the *parvathiyar*, or tax-collector, calling at her door presented him with her severed breasts on a banana leaf.

The story of Nangeli and her tragic self-mutilation is now widely represented as the signal act of defiance that led to the abolition of the iniquitous *mulakkaram* tax. But that is history as we would like it to be rather than what actually transpired. Now we must turn back to the government of Travancore under the ministry of the Nambudiri Brahmin Jayanthan Sankaran, which ended in a popular insurrection and his replacement as *dalawa* by the man who had led the insurrection: a Velir nobleman named Velayudhan Chempakaraman Thampi, popularly known as Velu Thampi Dalawa.[7]

Today Velu Thampi Dalawa is lauded with statues and a postage stamp as a great Keralan patriot, which indeed he was. But he was also a ruthless man, who saw to it that Jayanthan Sankaran and his sidekick, the Christian trader Thachil Matthoo, had their ears cut off and their properties confiscated. In his determination to balance the state's revenues Velu Thampi Dalawa appears also to have added to the taxes imposed by his predecessor.

Velu Thampi and the new British Resident, Colonel Macaulay, were now increasingly at loggerheads, both of them uncompromising characters used to having their way, particularly in their dealings with the weak-minded ruler of Travancore, Raja Balarama Varma. Velu Thampi's cost-cutting led to a mutiny of the Travancore army which required the intervention of the EICo's troops, which in turn led to the drawing up of a new treaty by which Travancore